Career guide for students

DON'T GUESS YOUR FUTURE

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This document contains Chapter One of ***Don't Guess Your Future: A Career Guide for Students***. The full book walks you through:

- How to discover your strengths and natural abilities
- How to match your passions to real career paths in Nigeria
- What to do if you chose the wrong course or career
- A step-by-step career planning framework for secondary and university students
- Real stories of young Nigerians who found direction and succeeded

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C H A P T E R O N E

The stage where futures are formed

I will never forget the day I sat down to fill out my JAMB form. I had been preparing for that moment for years. I knew exactly what I wanted: Computer Engineering at the University of Lagos. It wasn't a random choice. I had spent years imagining my self as an engineer, solving complex problems, building innovative systems. I researched the course. I read about the field. I convinced myself this was *my path*. So when the time came, I filled out the form with confidence.

First choice: Computer Engineering. First choice institution: University of Lagos. I thought I had it all figured out. But life had other plans. A few months later, the JAMB results came out. I opened mine with a mix of excitement and nervousness. And then I saw it. I didn't meet the cut-off mark for Engineering at the University of Lagos. My heart sank. The dream I had carried for years, the one I had built my entire academic focus around, was suddenly out of reach. I felt like I had failed. Worse, I felt *lost*. If this wasn't my path, then what was? But the disappointment didn't stop there. Even if I had met the cut-off mark, there was another hard truth I couldn't ignore: my sponsor couldn't afford the expenses at the University of Lagos.

The financial reality was undeniable. The dream university, the dream course, neither of them was possible anymore. I was stuck. Confused. Angry. Scared. For the first time, I realized something I wish I had understood earlier: Having a plan is not the same as having the *right* plan. I could have given up. I could have let disappointment paralyze me. But thankfully, I didn't have to figure it out alone. My teacher, Dr. Samuel Terungwa Dafa, sat me down and had a conversation that changed everything. He said to me, "Change your course," calmly. "Change your institution. This is not the end, it's a detour. And sometimes, detours lead you exactly where you need to be."

At first, I resisted. I didn't *want* to change my course. I didn't *want* to let go of the dream I had held onto for so long. But Dr. Dafa helped me see something I couldn't see on my own: Flexibility is not failure. Adaptation is not weakness. Sometimes, the best thing you can do is adjust your plan based on new information. So I took his advice. I changed my course. I changed my institution. And today, I am studying something completely different from what I originally planned, and I don't regret it.

Looking back, I realize how close I came to making a huge mistake. Not the mistake of choosing Computer Engineering, the mistake was thinking I had to stick to that plan no matter what, even when circumstances changed. The mistake was believing that one setback meant I had failed. But more than that, I realize now that I didn't have the guidance I needed when I was making those decisions. Yes, I did some research. I thought about what I wanted. But I didn't have a clear process for evaluating my options. I didn't know how to assess whether my chosen path truly aligned with my strengths, my values, and my circumstances. I didn't have a mentor guiding me through the process until it was almost too late.

And I know I'm not the only one. Every year, thousands of students across Nigeria sit down to fill out their JAMB forms, choose their courses, and select their institutions with little to no guidance. They choose based on: What their friends are choosing, what their parents want them to study, what sounds prestigious or "safe", and what they *think* will make them successful. And too often, they end up regretting those choices. Some struggle through courses they hate. Others drop out. Some spend years in careers that drain them, wondering, *"How did I end up here?"*

Secondary school is not just about passing exams. It's not just about getting into university. It's about something much bigger: It's the stage where your future begins to take shape. The decisions you make now, the subjects you focus on, the skills you develop, the course you choose, the institution you attend - will set the trajectory for the rest of your life. But here's the good news: You don't have to make these decisions blindly. You don't have to guess. You don't have to follow the crowd. You don't have to let fear or pressure dictate your choices. With the right guidance, tools, and mindset, you can make informed, intentional decisions that align with who you truly are.

This book is not going to tell you what career to choose. I can't do that because I don't know you. I don't know your strengths, interests, values, or circumstances. But what I *can* do is give you a process, a road-map for figuring it out yourself. Here's something I wish someone had told me when I was in JSS1 or JSS2: The earlier you start thinking about your future, the more options you'll have. I'm not saying you need to have your entire life planned out by age 13. That's unrealistic, and frankly, unhealthy. But what I *am* saying is this: The earlier you start exploring your interests, developing your skills, and understanding yourself, the easier it will be to make good decisions when the time comes.

If you're in JSS1-JSS3 right now, you have a gift: time. Use it wisely. Explore. Experiment. Ask questions. Try new things. Don't wait until SS3 to start thinking about your future. By then, many of your options will already be limited by the choices you've made (or haven't made). If you're in SS1-SS2, you're at the decision making stage. This is where clarity becomes critical. Don't rush. Don't guess. Take the time to understand yourself and evaluate your options carefully.

If you're in SS3, you might feel like it's too late. It's not. Yes, time is limited. Yes, the pressure is real. But even now, you can make informed decisions. Even now, you can adjust your plan. Even now, you can set yourself up for success. Wherever you are, the best time to start is now. I want to be honest with you: this process won't always be easy. You'll face pressure from parents, teachers, and friends. You'll doubt yourself. You'll feel overwhelmed. You'll wonder if you're making the right choice. That's normal. That's part of the journey. But here's what I want you to remember: Your future is not something that happens to you. It's something you build; one choice at a time, one step at a time. You don't have to be perfect. You don't have to have it all figured out. You just have to be willing to take the next step.
And that's what this book is here for - to help you take those
steps with clarity, confidence, and purpose.

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